

What After CAT 2025? Important Things To Do

The CAT exam is done. If you believe your performance ranks among the top percentiles (say 98 %ile and above, or especially 99 %ile+), congratulations — you now have exciting but critical next steps ahead. This is the ideal time to act decisively to convert your CAT success into a seat at a top B-school. Here's your checklist

1.Shortlist and research your target B-schools thoroughly

Apart from registering for the qualifying exams, you also need to register for each college within the stipulated deadlines to stand a chance. But with little time remaining and many deadlines already passed, you must start filling out the forms now. Waiting until after the CAT results are out will put you in a tough spot.

B-School	Deadline	Application Fee (₹)
ISBR Business School – PGDM	December 2, 2025	1,000
Great Lakes Institute of Management, Chennai (GLIM) – PGDM	December 4, 2025	2,200
GIM – PGDM	December 4, 2025	1,000
SCMHRD – MBA IDM	December 5, 2025	1,000
SCMHRD – MBA BA	December 5, 2025	1,000
SIBM Pune	December 5, 2025	1,000
XLRI – PGDBM + PGDHRM	December 5, 2025	2,200
GIBS Business School	December 5, 2025	950
FLAME University – MBA	December 7, 2025	2,000
XIM University – MBA BM	December 10, 2025	1,800
TISS – HRM	December 10, 2025	1,750
TISS – ODCL	December 10, 2025	1,750
XIM University – MBA RM	December 10, 2025	1,800

2. Keep your prep for all other MBA exams on track

Although most MBA aspirants dream of attending the IIMs, securing a seat there is challenging. Fortunately, several non-IIM colleges are just as good, if not better. Many of these colleges have separate exams besides the CAT for their admissions. It is strongly advised to sign up and diligently prepare for them. This will

ensure that even if you don't get into an IIM, you will still secure a place in a great business school. The most popular exams include SNAP, MICAT, NMAT, XAT, MAH MBA CET, CMAT, ATMA, and GMAT.

Even after you've taken your CAT exam, it is crucial to continue studying hard for the other exams. Brush up on your concepts again, practise different question sets, and give as many mocks as possible. Again, don't just wait for the CAT results to come out before taking further steps for your MBA.

3. Get all your documentation in order

Many of us have yet to collect our marksheets, certificates, and degrees from our schools and colleges. These documents are critical for the counselling process. Running around to gather them at the last minute will only add unnecessary stress to an already stressful process. Moreover, the earlier you get your documents in order, the faster you can identify and correct any errors. Most counselling processes require the following documents:

1. CAT 2025 scorecard
2. Certificates for class 10 and class 12, along with a passing certificate
3. Graduation certificate and marks card
4. Photo identity card
5. Photograph and signature
6. Professional work experience certificates
7. Valid caste certificate
8. For DAP/PwD applicants, issue the certificate according to the format provided on the CAT website.
9. Income certificate in the format provided on the CAT website (applicable for EWS applicants).
10. Certificates for extra-curricular activities

4. Start preparing for GD / WAT / PI rounds

Scoring high percentile only gets you a shortlisting call. The next stage — group discussion (GD), writing ability test (WAT), and personal interview (PI) — will decide your final fate.

- Begin sharpening your communication, analytical thinking, current-affairs knowledge, and clarity of opinion.
- Work on structuring your thoughts, writing crisp coherent essays (for WAT), and rehearse common interview questions (goals, weaknesses, "why MBA?", reasons for choosing a B-school, etc.).
- Brush up on general-knowledge, read newspapers or articles regularly, and build a habit of articulating viewpoints — this could make a strong difference.

5. Update and polish your profile (CV, extra-curriculars, certifications)

High CAT percentile makes you eligible, but admissions committees often look at your overall profile holistically — academics, work experience (if any), leadership or extracurriculars, diversity background, etc.

- Update your résumé / CV — make sure academics, work history, extracurricular activities, projects, certifications are properly documented.
- If you have space/time, take up short-term relevant certifications (online courses, workshops) to strengthen your profile.
- Gather evidence of extracurriculars, leadership roles, volunteer work, hobbies, any special achievements — this works in your favour during PI / WAT.

6. Plan for contingencies — even top percentilers should have backups

Even with 99 %ile+, conversion isn't guaranteed (because of diversity quotas, seat limitations, GD/PI performance, overall profile evaluation, category-wise cutoffs, etc.)

- Keep center-level entrance exams (if any) or other MBA entrance alternatives in mind (if relevant).
- Have a few “safe but good” B-schools on your list — ones with historically lower cut-offs, but decent placement & returns.
- Ensure fallback doesn't become a bad default — keep your aim high, but stay realistic.

7. Give yourself a short break — but stay focused

After months of intense CAT-preparation, it's tempting to take a long break — and that's okay. A little downtime helps you recharge. But given the tight timeline for applications, GD/PI prep and documentation, you should stay disciplined and balance rest with preparation.

Sometimes, this short pause can also help you reflect: what do you really want from an MBA? Which schools suit your long-term goals rather than just prestige?

Final Thoughts

Getting a top percentile in CAT gives you **an opportunity** — but not a guarantee. What you do in the next few weeks/months — your strategy, clarity, preparedness, and overall profile — matters even more.